

VOCABULARY · CULTURE · ACTIVITIES

BIRTHDAYS

Los cumpleaños

Everything you need to throw a birthday party in Spanish, with Spain 🇪🇸 and Argentina 🇦🇷 vocabulary

PONCHO
SPANISH

¡FELIZ CUMPLEAÑOS!

A birthday is the same everywhere and completely different everywhere: the same cake and candles, and then a song you've never heard, a piñata hanging from the ceiling, or somebody pulling your ears once for every year.

This resource collects more than 80 birthday words and expressions, each one with a real example sentence: how to wish someone happy birthday, how to invite people, the cake, the presents, the numbers and dates you need, and what happens at a birthday from Mexico to Argentina.

It is the friendliest vocabulary there is, because it's all about being nice to someone. At the end you'll find activities to check what you remember, and all the answers.

How to use it

1. **Read the word, then the sentence.** Words stick better when you see them in action.
2. **Say it out loud.** Try ¡Feliz cumpleaños! until it comes out in one go.
3. **Learn your own date first.** Mi cumpleaños es el... It's the sentence you'll use most.
4. **Try the activities** without looking back, then check the answers.

Cumplir años

In Spanish you don't 'have' a birthday, you **complete** years: **cumplo doce años** means 'I'm turning twelve'. That's where the word **cumpleaños** comes from: *cumplir* + *años*.

¿Cuántos años cumples? = **How old are you turning?**

Two countries, two words

When you see two options, the first is common in Spain 🇪🇸 and the second in Argentina 🇦🇷. Both are correct, and the cake tastes the same.

la tarta 🇪🇸 = **la torta** 🇦🇷

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01

¡FELICIDADES!

WISHING SOMEONE HAPPY BIRTHDAY

The words you say the second you walk through the door.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el cumpleaños	the birthday	*Hoy es el cumpleaños de mi hermana.* It's my sister's birthday today.
¡Feliz cumpleaños!	Happy birthday!	*¡Feliz cumpleaños, Lucía!* Happy birthday, Lucía!
¡Felicidades!	Congratulations! Many happy returns!	*¡Felicidades! ¡Qué mayor estás!* Happy birthday! How grown up you are!
¡Felicitaciones!	Congratulations!	*¡Felicitaciones por tus quince!* Congratulations on turning fifteen!
cumplir años	to turn (an age)	*Mañana cumplo trece años.* Tomorrow I turn thirteen.
el abrazo	the hug	*Le doy un abrazo muy fuerte.* I give her a great big hug.
el beso	the kiss	*Dos besos y a la mesa.* Two kisses and straight to the table.
celebrar	to celebrate	*Lo celebramos el sábado.* We're celebrating on Saturday.
el deseo	the wish	*Pide un deseo y no lo digas.* Make a wish and don't tell anyone.
soplar	to blow out	*Sopla las velas de una vez.* Blow the candles out in one go.

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01 · ¡FELICIDADES! WISHING SOMEONE HAPPY BIRTHDAY

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la vela	the candle	*Hay doce velas en la tarta.* There are twelve candles on the cake.
el tirón de orejas	the ear pull	*Un tirón de orejas por cada año.* One ear pull for each year.
aplaudir	to clap	*Todos aplauden y gritan.* Everyone claps and shouts.
la sorpresa	the surprise	*Fue una fiesta sorpresa.* It was a surprise party.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Spain and Argentina it is traditional to give the birthday person one gentle pull on the ear for each year, and one more para crecer, 'to grow'. Nobody is quite sure where it comes from, and everybody does it anyway.

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02

LA FIESTA Y LOS INVITADOS

THE PARTY AND THE GUESTS

Invitations, balloons, music and the house full of people.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la fiesta	the party	*La fiesta es en casa de Pablo.* The party is at Pablo's house.
la invitación	the invitation	*Me llegó la invitación por el móvil.* The invitation came to me on my phone.
invitar	to invite	*Invito a toda la clase.* I'm inviting the whole class.
el invitado / la invitada	the guest	*Somos veinte invitados.* There are twenty of us.
el globo	the balloon	*Inflamos globos de colores.* We blow up colourful balloons.
la guirnalda	the bunting	*Colgamos una guirnalda en la pared.* We hang bunting on the wall.
la música	the music	*Pongo música y empieza el baile.* I put music on and the dancing starts.
bailar	to dance	*Bailamos hasta cansarnos.* We dance until we're worn out.
el juego	the game	*Organizamos juegos para los pequeños.* We organise games for the little ones.
la piñata	the piñata	*La piñata está llena de caramelos.* The piñata is full of sweets.

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02 · LA FIESTA Y LOS INVITADOS THE PARTY AND THE GUESTS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la foto	the photograph	*Nos hacemos una foto todos juntos.* We take a photo all together.
la piscina 🇪🇸 la pileta 🇦🇷	the swimming pool	*En verano la fiesta es en la piscina.* In summer the party is at the pool.
guay 🇪🇸 copado 🇦🇷	cool, great	*¡Qué fiesta tan guay!* What a great party!
recoger	to tidy up	*Al final hay que recoger todo.* At the end we have to tidy everything up.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

The piñata is Mexican and it is traditionally broken blindfolded, while everybody sings a song that counts you down: you get only as long as the song lasts. The oldest ones had seven points, one for each of the seven deadly sins.

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03

LA TARTA Y LA COMIDA

THE CAKE AND THE FOOD

The moment the lights go off and the cake comes in.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la tarta 🇪🇸 la torta 🇦🇷	the cake	*La tarta es de chocolate.* The cake is chocolate.
el bizcocho	the sponge cake	*El bizcocho lo hizo mi abuela.* My grandmother made the sponge.
la nata 🇪🇸 la crema 🇦🇷	the cream	*Lleva nata y fresas por encima.* It has cream and strawberries on top.
la vela de cumpleaños	the birthday candle	*Pon una vela más, que cumple trece.* Put one more candle on, he's turning thirteen.
el trozo	the slice, the piece	*¿Me das un trozo pequeño?* Can I have a small slice?
el helado	the ice cream	*Con la tarta siempre hay helado.* There's always ice cream with the cake.
el bocadillo 🇪🇸 el sándwich 🇦🇷	the sandwich	*Hay bocadillos para todos.* There are sandwiches for everyone.
las patatas fritas	the crisps	*Las patatas fritas se acaban primero.* The crisps run out first.
las chucherías 🇪🇸 las golosinas 🇦🇷	the sweets	*La bolsa de chucherías es para llevar.* The bag of sweets is to take home.
el zumo 🇪🇸 el jugo 🇦🇷	the juice	*Un zumo de naranja para mí.* An orange juice for me.

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03 · LA TARTA Y LA COMIDA THE CAKE AND THE FOOD

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el refresco	the fizzy drink	*No queda refresco en la nevera.* There's no fizzy drink left in the fridge.
la merienda	the afternoon snack	*La fiesta es a la hora de la merienda.* The party is at snack time.
compartir	to share	*Compartimos todo lo que sobra.* We share whatever is left over.
¡Qué rico!	How delicious!	*¡Qué rica está la tarta!* The cake is delicious!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Argentina there is a game at children's parties with the cake: everyone puts a finger on the knife and the birthday child has to cut the first slice without anyone letting go. If the knife touches the plate, everybody shouts.

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04

LOS REGALOS

THE PRESENTS

Choosing one, wrapping it, and the face when it's opened.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el regalo	the present	*Este regalo es para ti.* This present is for you.
regalar	to give (as a present)	*Le regalo un libro.* I'm giving her a book.
envolver	to wrap	*Envuelvo el regalo con papel brillante.* I wrap the present in shiny paper.
el papel de regalo	the wrapping paper	*El papel de regalo tiene estrellas.* The wrapping paper has stars on it.
el lazo	the ribbon, the bow	*Le pongo un lazo rojo.* I put a red ribbon on it.
la tarjeta	the card	*Escribo una tarjeta a mano.* I write a card by hand.
abrir	to open	*¡Abre el mío primero!* Open mine first!
la sorpresa	the surprise	*¡Menuda sorpresa!* What a surprise!
el libro	the book	*Le encantan los libros de aventuras.* He loves adventure books.
el móvil 🇪🇸 el celular 🇦🇷	the mobile phone	*Me regalaron un móvil nuevo.* They gave me a new phone.

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04 · LOS REGALOS THE PRESENTS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
las zapatillas	the trainers	*Pedí unas zapatillas blancas.* I asked for white trainers.
la entrada	the ticket	*Me regalaron entradas para un concierto.* They gave me concert tickets.
gustar	to like	*¿Te gusta? Lo elegí yo.* Do you like it? I chose it myself.
¡Muchas gracias!	Thank you very much!	*¡Muchas gracias, me encanta!* Thank you so much, I love it!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Spain lots of people also celebrate el santo, the day of the saint they share a name with. If you are called Juan, 24 June is your day: another card, sometimes another little present, and no extra year.

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05

FECHAS, NÚMEROS Y EDADES

DATES, NUMBERS AND AGES

Everything you need to answer ¿cuándo es tu cumpleaños?

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
¿Cuándo es tu cumpleaños?	When is your birthday?	*—¿Cuándo es tu cumpleaños? —El tres de abril.* —When's your birthday? —The third of April.
Mi cumpleaños es el...	My birthday is on the...	*Mi cumpleaños es el veinte de julio.* My birthday is on the twentieth of July.
¿Cuántos años tienes?	How old are you?	*—¿Cuántos años tienes? —Tengo once.* —How old are you? —I'm eleven.
Tengo... años.	I'm ... years old.	*Tengo catorce años.* I'm fourteen.
uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco	1, 2, 3, 4, 5	*Cinco velas para cinco años.* Five candles for five years.
seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez	6, 7, 8, 9, 10	*Mi primo cumple diez.* My cousin is turning ten.
once, doce, trece, catorce, quince	11, 12, 13, 14, 15	*Quince es una edad especial.* Fifteen is a special age.
veinte, treinta, cuarenta	20, 30, 40	*Mi madre cumple cuarenta.* My mum is turning forty.
enero, febrero, marzo, abril	January, February, March, April	*Nací en abril.* I was born in April.
mayo, junio, julio, agosto	May, June, July, August	*En agosto no hay nadie en clase.* In August there's nobody at school.

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05 · FECHAS, NÚMEROS Y EDADES DATES, NUMBERS AND AGES

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre	September, October, November, December	*Mi cumple es en noviembre.* My birthday's in November.
nacer	to be born	*Nací en Manchester.* I was born in Manchester.
mayor / menor	older / younger	*Soy un año mayor que ella.* I'm a year older than her.
el cumple	birthday (short)	*¡Que tengas un cumple genial!* Have a great birthday!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Dates in Spanish go el + number + de + month, with no 'th' or 'st': el cinco de mayo, el veintiuno de agosto. The only one that sometimes changes is the first of the month, which can be el uno or el primero.

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06

CUMPLEAÑOS POR EL MUNDO HISPANO

BIRTHDAYS AROUND THE SPANISH-SPEAKING WORLD

Same cake, very different songs.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la canción de cumpleaños	the birthday song	*Cantamos la canción de cumpleaños.* We sing the birthday song.
«Cumpleaños feliz»	'Happy birthday to you'	*«Cumpleaños feliz» se canta en todas partes.* 'Cumpleaños feliz' is sung everywhere.
«Las mañanitas»	'Las mañanitas' (Mexican song)	*En México cantan «Las mañanitas».* In Mexico they sing 'Las mañanitas'.
la quinceañera	the fifteenth-birthday girl	*La quinceañera lleva un vestido largo.* The fifteen-year-old wears a long dress.
los quince	the fifteenth birthday party	*Sus quince fueron en un salón enorme.* Her fifteenth was in an enormous hall.
la tradición	the tradition	*Cada país tiene su tradición.* Each country has its own tradition.
la costumbre	the custom	*Es una costumbre muy antigua.* It's a very old custom.
el vals	the waltz	*Baila un vals con su padre.* She dances a waltz with her father.
la madrugada	the early hours	*En México cantan de madrugada.* In Mexico they sing before dawn.
despertar	to wake someone up	*Te despiertan cantando.* They wake you up singing.

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06 · CUMPLEAÑOS POR EL MUNDO HISPANO

BIRTHDAYS AROUND THE SPANISH-SPEAKING WORLD

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el mariachi	the mariachi band	*Vinieron mariachis a casa.* Mariachis came to the house.
el santo	the saint's day	*En España también se celebra el santo.* In Spain people celebrate their saint's day too.
el verano / el invierno	summer / winter	*En Argentina mi cumple cae en verano.* In Argentina my birthday falls in summer.
juntos / juntas	together	*Lo importante es estar juntos.* What matters is being together.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Mexico the birthday song is 'Las mañanitas', and it is traditionally sung very early in the morning, outside the bedroom door, sometimes with a whole mariachi band. The idea is that the first thing you hear on your birthday is people singing for you.

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07

FRASES DE CUMPLEAÑOS

BIRTHDAY PHRASES

Short sentences you could really say at a party. When there are two versions, the second is how you'd say it in Argentina.

¡Feliz cumpleaños!
Happy birthday!

¡Felicidades!
Many happy returns!

¿Cuándo es tu cumpleaños?
When is your birthday?

Mi cumpleaños es el doce de mayo.
My birthday is on the twelfth of May.

¿Cuántos años cumples?
How old are you turning?

Cumplo trece años.
I'm turning thirteen.

¿Vienes a mi fiesta?
Are you coming to my party?

Es el sábado a las cinco.
It's on Saturday at five.

Este regalo es para ti.
This present is for you.

¡Muchas gracias, me encanta!
Thank you so much, I love it!

Pide un deseo y sopla.
Make a wish and blow.

¡Qué fiesta tan guay! / ¡Qué fiesta tan copada!
What a great party!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

'Cumpleaños feliz' is sung to the same tune as 'Happy birthday to you', and most Spanish-speaking countries have their own extra verse after it. In Spain a lot of people carry straight on with ¡Que los cumplas feliz!

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08

¡A PRACTICAR!

ACTIVITIES

1 MATCH THEM UP

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish word or phrase.

1	el cumpleaños	☐	A	the cake
2	la tarta	☐	B	the invitation
3	la vela	☐	C	to blow out
4	el regalo	☐	D	the birthday
5	el globo	☐	E	to turn (an age)
6	la invitación	☐	F	the balloon
7	soplar	☐	G	the wish
8	el deseo	☐	H	the candle
9	la piñata	☐	I	the piñata
10	cumplir años	☐	J	the present

2 ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

Read each sentence and circle V (true) or F (false).

1. «Cumpleaños feliz» se canta en España y en Argentina. **V** **F**
2. La piñata es una tarta de chocolate. **V** **F**
3. En México se cantan «Las mañanitas». **V** **F**
4. Una quinceañera cumple cincuenta años. **V** **F**
5. En Argentina un cumpleaños de enero es en verano. **V** **F**
6. El tirón de orejas se da una vez cada diez años. **V** **F**

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3 LA FIESTA DE MATEO

Complete the story with the words from the box.

fiesta · cumple · globos · tarta · velas · deseo · regalos · amigos

El sábado fue la _____ de Mateo, que _____ doce años. Decoramos el salón con _____ de colores. Vinieron todos sus _____ del colegio. A las seis salió la _____ con doce _____ encima. Mateo pidió un _____ y sopló de una vez. Después abrió los _____ y bailamos hasta las nueve.

4 SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

Write the word used in Argentina next to the one used in Spain.

- **la tarta** → _____
- **la piscina** → _____
- **las chucherías** → _____
- **el móvil** → _____
- **el zumo** → _____
- **la nata** → _____
- **el bocadillo** → _____
- **guay** → _____

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5 SOPA DE LETRAS

Find the 12 words. They go across → or down ↓.

C	B	J	U	P	J	N	M	A	P	M	F
F	V	D	R	B	G	J	E	H	N	N	R
I	C	U	M	P	L	E	A	N	O	S	C
E	F	P	M	U	S	I	C	A	N	T	I
S	E	O	T	I	O	M	T	A	R	T	A
T	N	H	E	C	F	E	H	H	A	P	R
A	M	I	G	O	S	U	F	I	J	I	A
E	O	A	B	R	A	Z	O	T	G	N	D
M	V	U	S	O	P	L	A	R	L	A	E
R	E	G	A	L	O	L	E	S	O	T	S
V	V	E	L	A	S	B	P	T	B	A	E
N	N	N	N	D	R	N	B	G	O	C	O

CUMPLEANOS
TARTA
VELAS
REGALO
GLOBO
FIESTA
AMIGOS
SOPLAR
DESEO
PINATA
MUSICA
ABRAZO

6 PUT IT IN ORDER

Unscramble each sentence and write it on the line.

1. **cumpleaños / ¡Feliz**

_____

2. **es / de / Mi / mayo / el / doce / cumpleaños**

_____

3. **para / ti / Este / regalo / es**

_____

4. **deseo / Pide / un / y / sopla**

_____

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7 TU CUMPLEAÑOS PERFECTO

Write four or five sentences about your perfect birthday: when it is, how old you're turning, who you'd invite, what you'd eat and what you'd like as a present. Use at least six words from this resource.

Try: Mi cumpleaños es el... Cumplo... años. Invito a... Comemos... Me gustaría un...

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ANSWERS

1 · MATCH THEM UP

1–D, 2–A, 3–H, 4–J, 5–F, 6–B, 7–C, 8–G, 9–I, 10–E

2 · ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

1 V, 2 F, 3 V, 4 F, 5 V, 6 F

3 · LA FIESTA DE MATEO

1. fiesta, 2. cumple, 3. globos, 4. amigos, 5. tarta, 6. velas, 7. deseo, 8. regalos

4 · SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

la tarta → la torta; las chucherías → las golosinas; el zumo → el jugo; el bocadillo → el sándwich; la piscina → la pileta; el móvil → el celular; la nata → la crema; guay → copado

6 · PUT IT IN ORDER

¡Feliz cumpleaños! · Mi cumpleaños es el doce de mayo. · Este regalo es para ti. · Pide un deseo y sopla.

7 · TU CUMPLEAÑOS PERFECTO

Any answer that uses six words from this resource is perfect. Check two things: tengo / cumplo + años, and el + number + de + month for the date.

5 · SOPA DE LETRAS

C	B	J	U	P	J	N	M	A	P	M	F
F	V	D	R	B	G	J	E	H	N	N	R
I	C	U	M	P	L	E	A	N	O	S	C
E	F	P	M	U	S	I	C	A	N	T	I
S	E	O	T	I	O	M	T	A	R	T	A
T	N	H	E	C	F	E	H	H	A	P	R
A	M	I	G	O	S	U	F	I	J	I	A
E	O	A	B	R	A	Z	O	T	G	N	D
M	V	U	S	O	P	L	A	R	L	A	E
R	E	G	A	L	O	L	E	S	O	T	S
V	V	E	L	A	S	B	P	T	B	A	E
N	N	N	N	D	R	N	B	G	O	C	O

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¡QUE LOS CUMPLAS FELIZ!

SEE YOU SOON

Now you can invite people, sing, hand over a present and wish somebody a happy birthday in Spanish. Try it on the next person in your family who has one: it always works.

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SPANISH

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